

March 13, 2025

Attn: Faisal D'Souza
Networking and Information Technology Research and Development (NITRD)
National Coordination Office (NCO)
National Science Foundation

RE: U.S. AI Action Plan Request for Information

Dear Mr. D'Souza:

Dcode appreciates the opportunity to provide input on the U.S. AI Action Plan in response to President Trump's January 2025 Executive Order on AI, which prioritizes U.S. leadership in artificial intelligence, streamlining government adoption, and accelerating AI-driven national security and economic competitiveness.

Dcode strongly supports the administration's commitment to ensuring the United States remains at the forefront of AI innovation. To fully realize AI's potential, the AI Action Plan must emphasize not only AI development but also AI implementation and integration across government agencies at scale. The U.S. cannot afford for AI breakthroughs to remain in research and development cycles without structured, scalable pathways to deploy these capabilities into mission environments where they can deliver real value and results.

Aligning the AI Action Plan with the Executive Order: From Development to Deployment

President Trump's Executive Order underscores the need to remove bureaucratic barriers and ensure AI reaches operational users efficiently. While the U.S. leads the world in AI research and development, government agencies continue to struggle with integrating AI into mission operations due to outdated acquisition models, misaligned priorities, and a lack of clear transition pathways from prototype to full-scale deployment.

As a result, the current pace of AI adoption in government does not align with the urgency required to maintain technological superiority. Overcoming these systemic challenges requires a deliberate focus on accelerating AI deployment, ensuring that innovative capabilities move beyond research and into real-world mission environments. The AI Action Plan must establish clear, repeatable pathways for AI integration into operational settings. This includes:

- **Expand agile procurement** - Ensuring AI solutions transition from proof-of-concept to full deployment within months rather than years by expanding agile procurement mechanisms such as Other Transaction Authorities (OTAs), Small Business Innovation Research (SBIR) programs, and Replicator initiatives.
- **Validate in the real world** - Embed AI capabilities directly into operational units to ensure real-world validation and rapid scaling.

- **Strengthening cross-agency AI integration strategies** - Ensure AI deployments align with broader national security and intelligence priorities rather than remaining siloed within individual departments.
- **Eliminate barriers to divesting outdated technology** - Contracting constraints, misaligned budget priorities, and legacy system dependencies slow AI adoption. AI deployment should not be hampered by the inertia of maintaining obsolete capabilities that no longer serve mission needs.

Accelerating AI Deployment at Speed and Scale

To maintain U.S. AI leadership and meet the objectives outlined in the Executive Order, AI adoption must move from concept to operational reality at the speed of relevance. The AI Action Plan should:

- Mandate a commercial-first approach to ensure agencies prioritize proven private-sector AI solutions over costly efforts to recreate existing technology within traditional defense contractors.
- Maximize existing DoD AI investments by aligning with Replicator, DIU, and other AI adoption initiatives, ensuring AI transitions efficiently into operational programs while eliminating redundant spending across agencies.
- Remove systemic obstacles to scaling AI by streamlining acquisition, ensuring flexible funding mechanisms, and establishing direct pathways for AI insertion into mission operations.

Leveraging Commercial AI for National Security and Economic Competitiveness

The private sector has driven the most significant advancements in AI, and government adoption strategies must be structured to take full advantage of commercial AI innovations. The AI Action Plan should:

- Mandate a commercial-first approach to AI procurement, ensuring agencies prioritize proven private sector AI solutions over costly, taxpayer-funded efforts to rebuild existing technology within traditional defense contractors.
- Maximize existing DoD AI investments by aligning with Replicator, DIU, and other AI adoption initiatives, ensuring seamless integration into operational programs while eliminating duplicative efforts and redundant spending across agencies.
- Ensure AI implementation efforts focus on real mission needs, preventing inefficiencies caused by disconnected research projects that do not translate into operational impact.

Operational AI Integration for Scalable Deployment

While AI research remains critical, the government must also establish structured pathways for AI implementation and scaling to ensure that AI capabilities transition from pilots to operational use. This requires a dedicated framework embedded within agencies, defense programs, and intelligence units to drive real adoption, integration, and mission impact.

To ensure AI deployment remains relevant and adaptive, the government should:

- Embed AI transition teams within agencies to drive integration into mission-critical workflows, ensuring solutions are fielded where they are most needed.
- Develop dynamic AI implementation playbooks, leveraging private sector expertise to create living documents that evolve alongside advancements in AI technology. Standardization should enable adoption while remaining flexible enough to keep pace with rapid innovation.
- Leverage commercial AI best practices to ensure government adoption strategies remain agile, scalable, and focused on outcomes.

Building a Highly Advanced, AI-Ready Workforce

AI adoption is not just a technology challenge—it is also a workforce challenge. The U.S. must take proactive steps to develop an AI-capable workforce that can effectively evaluate, integrate, and deploy AI solutions across mission environments. The AI Action Plan should:

- Invest in AI-focused workforce development programs that prepare engineers, technologists, and mission operators to work with AI systems in real-world applications.
- Fast-track hiring pathways for AI talent in national security roles, ensuring agencies can access top-tier AI professionals without being outcompeted by the private sector.
- Establish AI innovation pipelines in partnership with universities and advanced technology companies, ensuring a steady flow of highly skilled specialists into mission-critical roles.
- Prioritize continuous AI upskilling programs that leverage private sector expertise to ensure training materials remain current, adaptive, and mission-focused, rather than becoming obsolete government curricula.

Dcode's Role in AI Adoption and National Security

Dcode has worked with over 300 advanced technology companies to accelerate technology adoption across government and defense sectors. Through our Rapid Acquisition Integration Cell (RAIC) and Data/AI Solution Integration Cell (DASIC) initiatives, we provide a structured approach to AI transition that:

- Moves AI from pilot projects to fully funded, operational deployments within federal agencies and defense programs.
- Navigates bureaucratic and acquisition challenges to ensure AI solutions are integrated efficiently and at scale.
- Conducts rigorous AI solution evaluations to ensure the right technologies are deployed for the right missions.
- Focuses on cutting-edge AI applications in cybersecurity, quantum computing, and edge computing to enhance mission readiness and national security capabilities.

Dcode works directly with government leaders to ensure AI solutions are rapidly deployed where they can have the greatest mission impact

Ensuring the U.S. Leads in AI Adoption

AI is no longer just a research priority—it is an operational necessity. The success of the AI Action Plan will be measured not by the volume of AI research conducted but by the number of AI solutions successfully fielded and scaled across government and national security missions.

For the U.S. to maintain its competitive edge, AI must move beyond the lab and into real-world environments where it can enhance operational decision-making, increase mission efficiency, and provide asymmetric advantages against adversaries. The government must establish structured mechanisms to evaluate, integrate, and fund AI solutions while eliminating the bureaucratic obstacles that prevent promising technologies from reaching the field.

Dcode has worked extensively with emerging AI, cybersecurity, and advanced technology companies to bridge the gap between innovation and implementation. Through initiatives such as RAIC and DASIC, Dcode is working to accelerate AI adoption by developing structured transition pathways, identifying strategic investment opportunities, and supporting efforts to retire outdated technologies that slow deployment.

The AI Action Plan must reflect this urgency by ensuring AI adoption is not an afterthought but a core national security priority. Dcode remains committed to supporting these efforts and working alongside government leaders to ensure that AI capabilities not only exist but are fully operational, scalable, and delivering mission impact at speed.

We appreciate the opportunity to contribute to this discussion and look forward to continued collaboration with the administration.

Sincerely,
Meg Vorland
Managing Partner, Dcode Capital
Cofounder, Dcode

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